Eight Questions Families Ask When a Parent Is Still Independent and They Want to Plan Ahead

Plain, general answers, and where to take the questions that are about Mom herself.

Mom is still doing things her own way, and you'd like to plan ahead with her. These are the questions families in that spot ask most, including the ones that are awkward to raise.

Every answer here is general. Where a question depends on knowing Mom, the answer says who to take it to.

1 Nothing is wrong. Why write anything down now?

Because a quiet week is the easy time to do it. The Family Caregiver Alliance tells brothers and sisters that if there's no emergency, they can allow some time to get everyone on the same page. Writing down how Mom's week works doesn't mean anything is about to change. It gives the family one shared place to start from. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you've noticed something about her health and wonder whether it matters. That is a question for her doctor, and it doesn't need a family page first.

2 What help is already being provided?

Usually more than anyone has counted. Caregiving often creeps up, the Family Caregiver Alliance says: it starts with a load of laundry or a ride to an appointment. MedlinePlus lists the everyday kinds, among them running errands, driving to appointments, housework and cooking, arranging care and keeping someone company. About 80 percent of care at home is provided by unpaid caregivers, so it is worth writing down who does each of those for Mom, and how often. [2] [3] [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** you want to know whether the help in place is the right amount. Listing it is the family's part. What it adds up to is for a professional who assesses her, such as your care consultant.

3 Who actually knows Mom's daily routine?

Mom does, first. After her, the knowledge is usually spread across several people who each see different hours of the week. The Family Caregiver Alliance notes that parents often tell their kids different things about how they're doing, which is a good reason to pool what you each know. Its family-meeting guide counts a family friend or a neighbor as part of the team, so ask them too. [1] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** nobody can describe some part of her week, even after you've asked her. Write “not yet known” and bring the question to your next care conversation. Don't fill it in with a guess.

4 How do we bring this up without making Mom feel managed?

Ask her; don't announce a decision. AARP's planning guide says a plan should never be made without the participation, knowledge and consent of the person it's about, and that the most important thing is to listen. “Walk me through a normal week” is an invitation. The guide also says the conversation will likely take place over time, so a short first try is fine. [6] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the conversation keeps stalling and the family would like help with it. The Family Caregiver Alliance says an outside facilitator, such as a social worker or minister, can help a family communicate.

5 My sister and I describe Mom's week differently. Which of us is right?

Probably both. It's natural, the Family Caregiver Alliance says, for siblings to take in the situation at different times and in different ways, and each person has a different relationship with a parent. The one who visits on Sundays and the one who drives her on Thursdays see different hours of the same week. Write both versions down with a name beside each, and don't settle it between yourselves. [1]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the difference is about her health or what she needs. The Family Caregiver Alliance says professionals outside the family, such as physicians, social workers or geriatric care managers, can help siblings establish what is real about a parent's health and needs.

6 What information should we organize while there is time?

Start with how the week works: where she lives, who helps, and what each person does. Then the practical list. AARP's guide suggests keeping the contact information for doctors and neighbors in one list, and noting where each important item is kept. The CDC's guidance on written care plans adds her health care providers with their contact details, her medicines and her emergency contacts. [6] [7] [8]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the family would like to see Mom's medical information. That is hers to share. Doctors' offices have their own forms for naming who may be told what, so ask each office.

7 Where should the page live, and when do we look at it again?

Keep it where the family can find it, and tell everyone where that is. One reason the CDC gives for a written care plan is that it keeps important information in one place, and the same goes for a family's page. Then choose what brings you back to it. The CDC suggests every year, or sooner after a change in health or medicines, and the Family Caregiver Alliance reminds families that a family meeting is not a one-time event. [7] [5]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** something changes in her health. Update the page, and take the health question itself to her doctor.

8 Does planning ahead mean deciding where Mom will live?

No. Preparation doesn't have to start with choosing a place; it can start with a conversation about daily life, the help already there, and who knows what. The federal long-term care site says most people can live at home for many years with help from family and friends and from community support. A page about Mom's week commits nobody to anything. [4]

> **ASK A PROFESSIONAL WHEN** the family does start to weigh a change in where Mom lives. That is a decision to make with her and with a professional who has assessed her, not from a page of family notes.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't answer anything about Mom herself: how she's managing, what she needs, or what the family should decide. Those questions need someone who knows her and, where her health is involved, someone who has assessed her.

Ready for the next step?

You've got general answers and a clearer idea of what to ask at home. The care interview takes on the particulars: it goes through Mom's daily life one area at a time, including the ones nobody has brought up, and builds a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving with Your Siblings
2. Family Caregiver Alliance, Caregiving 101: On Being a Caregiver
3. MedlinePlus (National Library of Medicine), Caregivers
4. Administration for Community Living (LongTermCare.gov), Who Will Provide Your Care?
5. Family Caregiver Alliance, Holding a Family Meeting
6. AARP, Prepare to Care: A Planning Guide for Families
7. Centers for Disease Control and Prevention, Steps for Creating and Maintaining a Care Plan
8. National Institute on Aging (NIH), Taking Someone to a Doctor’s Appointment: Tips for Caregivers